

AUTONOMY LEVEL 5

Your approval
gate has a
back door.

#4 in the silent-failure series

WHAT WAS RECORDED

1 → 4

One approval was recorded. The action ran four times.

nothing was bypassed maliciously · nobody did anything wrong



WHAT WE ALL ASSUME



A gate exists, so the gate holds.

Level 3 means the system acts
and a human approves the
irreversible. The gate is the
whole safety claim.



THE BREAK



How many paths reach the action, and how many cross the gate?

A control-flow question, and
one almost nobody draws.

THE PATH EVERYONE DRAWS

FIRST RUN



Approval happens once, on the way in. This is the diagram in the design doc.

THE PATH NOBODY DRAWS

AFTER A FAILURE



The request re-enters at the step that failed — which is after approval, because approval already happened.

drawn by somebody thinking about resilience, not about authority

WHY NOTHING FLAGS IT

The gate logs
one approval
and one action.

Which is exactly what a correct
run looks like. Executions two,
three and four are invisible to
it.

it counts approvals, not effects



THE FIX



Count paths to the effect, not approvals at the gate.

Twice now the count has been smaller than the list of paths, and both times the extra one was a retry.

an approval gate that counts approvals is measuring itself



THE TEST



List every path that can reach the irreversible call.

Then count how many cross
the gate. If the two numbers
differ, the difference is your
real autonomy level.

how would it know if it had stopped working?

WHERE THIS STOPS WORKING

An idempotent effect does not need this.

If running it four times and running it once are the same, retry is free. The trouble is that almost nothing is idempotent by accident.

the rule has an edge, and this is it